Northwind Retail Group

IT & Data Security Policy — Effective January 1, 2026 (fictional, for demo purposes only)

1. Password and Account Security

All employees must use a unique password of at least 12 characters for their Northwind corporate account, combining upper and lower case letters, numbers, and a symbol. Passwords must be changed immediately if an employee suspects their account has been compromised, and must never be shared with another employee, contractor, or third party under any circumstance. Multi-factor authentication (MFA) is mandatory for all accounts with access to customer data, financial systems, or source code repositories. Accounts left inactive for more than 90 days are automatically disabled and must be reactivated through the IT service desk.

2. Device and Endpoint Management

Company-issued laptops must have full-disk encryption, an approved endpoint security agent, and automatic screen lock after 5 minutes of inactivity enabled at all times. Employees may not install unapproved software or disable security agents on company devices without written authorization from the IT Security team. Lost or stolen devices must be reported to IT Security within 24 hours so the device can be remotely locked and wiped. Personal devices used to access company email or chat must be enrolled in the mobile device management (MDM) system.

3. Data Classification and Handling

Company data is classified into three tiers: Public, Internal, and Restricted. Restricted data includes customer personal information, payment details, and unreleased financial results, and may only be stored in approved company systems - never on personal cloud storage, personal email, or removable USB drives. Internal data may be shared with employees and approved contractors but not posted publicly. Any suspected exposure of Restricted data must be reported immediately to the Data Protection Officer, regardless of how minor it may seem.

4. Acceptable Use of Company Systems

Company systems, network access, and email are provided for business purposes. Limited personal use is permitted provided it does not interfere with work, consume excessive bandwidth, or involve illegal, discriminatory, or offensive content. Employees must not use company systems to access or distribute pirated software, unlicensed media, or any material that violates Northwind's Code of Conduct. IT Security reserves the right to monitor network traffic and system logs for security purposes in accordance with applicable law.

5. Incident Reporting

Any suspected phishing email, malware infection, unauthorized access attempt, or other security incident must be reported to security@northwindretail.example within 1 hour of discovery, and the affected device disconnected from the network if malware is suspected. Do not attempt to investigate or remediate a suspected breach yourself - IT Security will coordinate the response. Employees who report a genuine mistake in good faith (such as clicking a phishing link) will not face disciplinary action for the report itself.

6. Remote Access and VPN

Remote access to internal systems requires the company VPN client with MFA enabled; direct remote desktop connections to internal servers from outside the corporate network are prohibited. Split-tunneling must be disabled while connected to the VPN so that all traffic is routed through Northwind's security monitoring. Public Wi-Fi (airports, cafes, hotels) may only be used to access company systems through the VPN, never as a direct connection.